

w1.1- Team Structure

Team-Based Projects



Team-based **projects are key to**
the effective use of Six Sigma.

key to the effective
use of Six Sigma.



Advantages of Team-Based Projects

- Teams decisions are of higher quality and creativity and generally receive **stronger support.**
- Cross-functional teams help break down barriers between different parts of the organization.
- Participation on teams **helps improve communication** leadership, and problem-solving skills.
- If one person on the team knows the answer, then all team members learn and benefit.



than individuals working alone.

Potential Disadvantages of Team-Based Projects

- Teams typically require more time than individuals.
- Confidentiality may be an issue.
- Team members must be able to work together.
- Peer pressure to avoid or focus on certain issues may be present.
- Groupthink can occur.
- Everyone on the team must have some knowledge of the subject or be able to contribute in some other way.



However, there are also

Selecting Project Team Members

Six Sigma project teams should consist of **5 to 7 full-time team members**, with other members participating **on a limited / ad hoc basis** as needed.



What should a Six Sigma project team look like?



Project team members can be:

- Full-Time / Core
- Ad-Hoc
- Resource only



Six-sigma project team
members can be full-time or





Full-time / core team members should include:

- A Black Belt (or Green Belt) team leader
- **Subject Matter Experts ("SME's")**
- People who will be affected by the project, including customers.
- People who have no prior knowledge of the project area.
- A variety of perspectives

Full-time team members
should typically include;



w1.1- Team Structure.mp4

File View Playback Video Subtitles Audio Settings Help



to describe an elephant
reminds us that



00:05:38 / 00:07:14

70

The most effective structure for Six Sigma project teams is **a cross-functional, multi-level team** with a goal of improving quality and process performance. Six Sigma **always uses teams** because their advantages **(higher quality decisions, breakdown of barriers)** skill improvement) significantly outweigh the disadvantages (slower decision-making, potential for groupthink).

Six Sigma Team Structure Essentials

Team Size and Types

- **Ideal Size:** Typically **five to seven full-time members**.
 - Teams larger than seven are difficult to manage; smaller teams may not handle the workload.
- **Member Categories:**
 1. **Full-time or Core Members:** Participate in all team meetings, activities, and task assignments.
 2. **Ad Hoc Members:** Attend only when their **specific expertise is needed** (e.g., IT specialists, accountants).
 3. **Resource-Only Members:** Provide resources, coaching, or training. These often include **Master Black Belts** (for training/coaching), **Process Owners** (responsible for the process being addressed), and **Project Champions** (who provide resources like meeting space, data, or funds).

Required Roles and Perspectives

Full-time team members must be selected to ensure a diverse and effective group:

- **Six Sigma Professional Leader:**
 - **Black Belts** are used for larger, cross-functional projects.
 - **Green Belts** are used for smaller, non-cross-functional projects.
- **Subject Matter Experts (SMEs):** People knowledgeable about the project areas, including:
 - Science, technology, process design, data analysis, or regulatory requirements.
 - Especially those who **do the work on a daily basis.**
- **Internal Customers:** People who will be **affected by the project's changes.**
- **Outsider Perspective:** Individuals with **no prior knowledge** of the project area. Their viewpoint helps the team avoid complacency and the "that's the way we've always done it" mentality.
- **Variety of Perspectives:** This is critical. Like the parable of the blind men and the elephant, processes cannot be fully understood without seeing them from different angles. Diversity should include different positions, departments, backgrounds, education, **personalities, and approaches** (often assessed using tests like Myers-Briggs or Belbin's team roles) .

Key Advantages and Disadvantages

Advantages

Higher Quality & Creativity: Better decisions due to diverse perspectives and open discussion.

Breaks Down Barriers: **Cross-functional** cooperation across the organization.

Skill Improvement: Improves communication, leadership, and problem-solving skills for members.

Stronger Support: Decisions are better supported organization-wide.

Disadvantages (and Mitigation)

Requires More Time: Teams take longer to make decisions than individuals.

Confidentiality Issues: May be a concern before management makes a decision.

Groupthink/Peer Pressure: Desire to get along **discourages individual creativity** (avoided via strong leadership and training).

Requires Training: Needs strong leadership and process/interpersonal skills training.

w1.2- Team Roles and Responsibilities

Team Leader

- The team leader is responsible for directing the team's activities toward the successful and timely completion of the team's project as defined in the project charter.



First, the team leader.

The team leader's responsibilities include:

- Ensuring that the team stays on task and schedule
- Scheduling meeting rooms and equipment
- Conducting meetings
- Ensuring that the process improvement methodology is followed correctly
- Arranging for training or other resources for the team
- Encouraging the participation of all members of the team
- Resolving team problems in a "win-win" manner
- Working with problem team members on a one-to-one basis to resolve problems
- Working between meetings with team members to ensure the timely completion of assigned tasks



KENNESAW STATE
UNIVERSITY

The team leaders responsibilities can
include ensuring that the team stays on

Team Members



- Team members will work together during team meetings to complete the project to the best of their ability.
- They will also complete tasks assigned to them during the meetings.

the best of their ability as
directed by the team leader.



Optional Team Member Roles

- The team reporter (archivist, recorder, historian) must create a record of the team's activities and decisions.



Optional team member roles include the team reporter and timekeeper.





- The team's timekeeper is responsible for watching the time **to ensure that the team** stays on schedule as it works through each meeting's agenda.

Some teams also find it helpful to have someone other than the team leader be

Team Facilitator



- Team facilitators provide assistance to the team in whatever capacity is necessary to make the team a success, including training.
- Master Black Belts often perform the role of the Facilitator, but not all Facilitators are Master Black Belts.



The Critical Role of the Process Owner

- Process owners are responsible for the **management of processes** within the organization.
- They are the primary **internal customers** of the Six Sigma project team.



The critical role of the process owner.

The Project Champion



- Middle or senior level executives who sponsor a specific Six Sigma project and help the team resolve any problems beyond their level of authority.

senior level executive who sponsors
that specific Six Sigma project.



KENNESAW STATE
UNIVERSITY

The key roles associated with a Six Sigma project team are the **Team Leader** (Black or Green Belt), **Team Members**, **Team Facilitator**, **Process Owner**, and **Project Champion**.

Six Sigma Staff Hierarchy



Six Sigma Team Roles and Responsibilities

1. Team Leader (Black Belt or **Green Belt**)

The Team Leader is responsible for **directing the team's day-to-day activities** to ensure the project charter is successfully attained efficiently.

Project Scope	Leader Role
Larger-scale, cross-functional projects	Black Belt
Smaller-scale, single-department projects	Green Belt

Key Responsibilities:

- Ensuring the team **stays on task and schedule.**
- Arranging for **meeting rooms and equipment.**
- Conducting **effective and efficient meetings.**
- Ensuring the process improvement methodology (like **DMAIC**) is followed correctly.
- Arranging for or assisting in providing **training and resources.**
- Creating a comfortable atmosphere that encourages **participation and open exchange of ideas.**
- **Resolving team problems** in a win-win manner and preventing conflict.
- Working with team members one-on-one and between meetings to ensure **timely completion of assigned tasks.**

2. Team Members

Team members work together, as directed by the Team Leader, to complete the project to the best of their ability.

Key Responsibilities:

- Working together **during team meetings** to advance the project.
- Working **outside of team meetings** to complete tasks assigned by the team.

Optional Roles within the Team Members:

- **Team Reporter (Archivist, Recorder, Historian):** Creates a record of the team's activities and decisions, takes and distributes **meeting minutes**, and documents problem-solving results. This role is generally preferred to be handled by the same person throughout the project.
- **Team Timekeeper:** Ensures the team stays on schedule **during meetings by watching the** time against the agenda. This role can be rotated or assigned to one person for the duration of the project.

3. Team Facilitator (Often a Master Black Belt)

The Facilitator provides **assistance to the team** in whatever capacity is necessary to make the team a success; their job is to make it as easy as possible for the team to succeed.

Key Responsibilities:

- Assigned before the team is formed to participate **in member identification** and charter development.
- Helps with the Team Leader's responsibilities if the leader is new, until they can handle them alone.
- Often **provides training** for the team as needed, based on their existing Six Sigma experience.
- Must always be **knowledgeable and experienced in Six Sigma.**

4. Process Owner

The Process Owner is the individual **responsible for the management of the process** being addressed by the project. They receive the solution created by the team.

Key Responsibilities:

- They are the **primary internal customer** of the project team.
- Responsible for **managing the improved process** after the Six Sigma improvements are implemented.
- The project team works for the Process Owner, and both share responsibility for the project's success or failure.
- Must work with the team to ensure they understand the owner's **needs and expectations**, and that the owner ultimately **accepts and supports** the team's analysis and solutions.

5. Project Champion

The Champion is a **middle or senior-level executive** who **sponsors** the specific Six Sigma project.

Key Responsibilities:

- Helps the team with any problems **beyond the team's level of authority**.
- Ensures that **company resources** are available to the team as needed.
- Resolves any **cross-functional issues** that arise.

w1.3- Stages of Team Development

The Stages of Team Development



Forming

- During the initial Forming stage, team members are usually **positive, polite and excited** about the task ahead.
- Their main concern is what their roles will be and how the team will work.
- The project charter can be a very helpful tool for establishing the team's objectives and maintaining focus during this time.



polite and excited about the task ahead.

Storming

- During the storming stage, team members “jockey” **for position** on the team and try to clarify their roles and how the team will work together.
- They may begin to feel overwhelmed by the work ahead or uncomfortable with the team’s approach.
- Many teams fail when they get to this stage, **especially if the leader** is not able to provide the necessary level of support.
- During storming, the team leader should remain positive and firm, and focus on building good **relationships between team members.**



During the storming stage, team members
often began to jockey for position on

Norming



- Team members begin to respect the **leader's authority and ability** in the norming stage.
- They are comfortable asking each other for help, disagreeing constructively, etc.
- The team becomes **more committed to each other** and the team goal, and progress toward the goal becomes visible.
- The team leader should begin to let the team take responsibility for the team's progress.

As the teams hierarchy is established and
the team leader shows that he or

Performing



- The team has evolved into an effective unit and is **making good progress** toward the team's goal.
- The team leader is able to delegate a great deal of the work and can focus on developing team members.

Adjourning or Mourning



- Members of effective teams typically become “close” during the process and miss the team after it is over.
- Before they adjourn, teams should always celebrate their achievements, regardless of the ultimate outcome of the project.
- Contribution to the team should be formally acknowledged.



Final Tips

- Leave plenty of time for coaching team members through the "Forming," "Storming," and "Norming" stages.
- Continually communicate team progress against milestone targets.
- These stages **don't apply to all teams.**
- Don't let team members use knowledge of the "storming" stage as an excuse for bad behavior.



Some final tips.

The stages of team development, first proposed by psychologist **Bruce Tuckman in 1965**, describe the predictable path a group follows as it evolves into a fully functioning team. This model is known as **Forming, Storming, Norming, Performing** with a fifth stage, **Adjourning (or Mourning)**, added later. .

The Five Stages of Team Development

1. Forming

- **Team Behavior:** Members are typically **positive, polite, and excited**, but also anxious about their roles and responsibilities. The discussion centers on how the team will work. This stage is usually very brief (often only one meeting).
- **Leader Role:** The leader must play a **dominant role** to establish objectives and maintain focus. The **Project Charter** is a helpful tool here.

2. Storming

- **Team Behavior:** This is the **most challenging stage**. Members **jockey for position**, clarify their roles, and may feel overwhelmed or uncomfortable with the team's approach. The **leader's authority may be challenged**, the team's purpose may be questioned, and some members may resist tasks. Many teams fail here.
- **Leader Role:** The leader must remain **positive and firm**. The focus is on **building good relationships** by teaching members about conflict resolution, effective communication, and the stages of team development itself.

3. Norming

- **Team Behavior:** The team's **hierarchy is established**, and members begin to **respect and accept the leader's authority**. Members know each other better, are comfortable asking for help, and can **disagree constructively** while communicating honestly. **Commitment to the team goal becomes visible**, and the team may begin to socialize. Teams may cycle between Storming and Norming as new tasks arrive, but Storming becomes rare.
- **Leader Role:** The leader should start to **delegate more work** and let the team take more responsibility for its own progress. **Team-building** or social events are useful.

4. Performing

- **Team Behavior:** The team has evolved into an **effective unit** that is making **good progress toward its goals**. Changes to the team have a minimal impact on its culture or effectiveness.
- **Leader Role:** The leader should **delegate as much work as possible** and focus on **developing team members**.

5. Adjourning (or Mourning)

- **Team Behavior:** The project concludes, and the team dissolves. Members may feel close and **miss the team** after it ends (mourning), especially if the team worked well together. This stage can be stressful if future roles or job security are uncertain.
- **Leader Role:** Six Sigma teams should **celebrate their achievements**. The leader must formally **acknowledge each member's contribution** through a documented review of their participation.

Final Tips for Team Leaders

- **Schedule Time for Coaching:** Allocate plenty of time to coach members through the early stages (**Forming, Storming, and Norming**).
- **Show Progress:** Regularly discuss the team's progress against appropriate milestone targets to help members see they are moving forward, especially during longer projects.
- **Flexibility:** Not all teams follow these stages strictly; some teams **may skip stages** if they have prior experience working together or with Six Sigma.
- **Manage Behavior:** Do not allow team members to use their knowledge of the **Storming stage as an excuse for bad behavior**.